Step 4: AI-Assisted Narrative and Step 5: Team Sync and Gap Check

Step 4:

From January to July 2026, Meridian's biggest budget problem was Research & Development spending. We budgeted $0.55 million but spent $3.03 million, which is $2.49 million (455%) more than planned. This was a persistent trend, not a one-time spike: spending was over budget in all seven months. A one-time spike is a single unusual month and usually needs only a note. A persistent trend repeats month after month, so the board should review the budget itself. General & Administrative spending shows the same pattern, at $1.90 million over budget. None of our flagged line items was a one-time spike. Sales & Marketing revenue was also well above plan, by $2.16 million. Operations COGS was the only line under budget, by $0.26 million. Our data shows how large and how consistent these differences are, but it does not show why they happened, so we are not drawing conclusions about the causes.

- We checked every figure in the narrative against our step 2 results before finalizing and all matched.

Step 5:

Our single biggest finding that we found in our group was the dollar variance shown in May. It was shown to be the highest point throughout all of the months (January – July).